

Daily Mail

No. 306

THE HERITAGE of FLEET STREET

April 2026

The Daily Mail was founded in 1896 by two Harmsworth brothers, later known as Lord Northcliffe and Lord Rothermere. It was cheap, clear, and aimed at a wide audience, with human interest stories and concise coverage. The first print run was nearly 400,000, and by 1902 circulation passed a million, making it the world's largest newspaper. Harmsworth (later Rothermere) ran the business, while Northcliffe was editor.

The paper combined politics and entertainment, taking an imperialist stance while also targeting women readers and promoting modern technology. It supported aviation, offering prizes for pioneering flights, including £30,000 to Amy Johnson for her solo Atlantic flight in 1930. Northcliffe's style mixed news and entertainment to appeal to the public.

After Northcliffe died in 1922, Lord Rothermere took control. He initially supported Mussolini and the British Union of Fascists, though this ended in 1934. The paper opposed Jewish refugees and backed appeasement before World War II. After the war, editor David English modernized the paper, increasing circulation and launching the Mail on Sunday in 1982. Today, it is owned by Daily Mail and General Trust plc, with the 4th Viscount Rothermere as chairman.